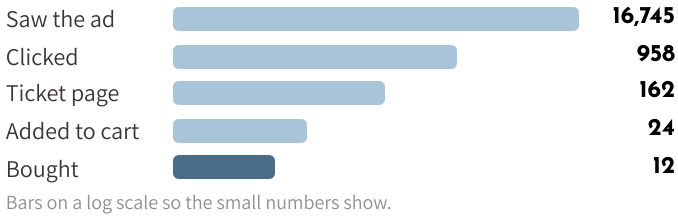
HOW SHOWS ACTUALLY SELL.

Hey, Sam here. I own Sisyphus in Minneapolis. Here's what two recent headliner weekends taught us, with the real numbers.

HEADLINER #1: TRACKED ADS

$159	$738	4.6x	$13
ad spend	tickets sold by ads	return	per order

FROM SCROLL TO SEAT



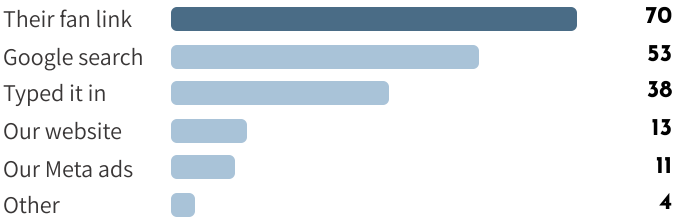
Bars on a log scale so the small numbers show.

- **Show week paid best.** 3.3x the week before, 5.5x show week. Start 2 to 3 weeks out so the good stretch is longer.
- **One ad for the whole run** returned 5.1x. A single-night ad: 3.1x.
- **Most people saw it once.** Room to spend more before anyone got sick of it.

HEADLINER #2: THE FAN LIST

52	88	3+1
sold after email #1	sold after email #2	sold out, added a show

WHERE 189 TICKETS CAME FROM



- **The rush started the day each email went out.** Most of the fan-link sales came from their list.
- **$301 on Punchup ads.** 337 clicks, no sales count, and a reported frequency of 0.7. Fewer than one view per person who saw it. Nobody can tell you what it sold.
- **Our ads did less here.** Their fans did the heavy lifting. That's why you want both.

WHAT SELLS

- Ads set to "Sales," tracked to a purchase
- A second ad to people who looked and didn't buy
- Your email list, timed with the venue's ads
- Video clips over still photos

WHAT BURNS MONEY

- "Traffic" and "awareness" ads. Ours spent and sold zero
- Ads that report clicks, not sales
- Posting the ticket link once
- Starting the week of the show

The pixel, in one breath: a tiny bit of code on the ticket page that remembers who looked and who bought. It's how we know an ad paid back 4.6x, and how we find the 12 people who left tickets in a cart. One more ad to them costs pennies. Cheapest sale there is.

FROM THE BOOKING SIDE

1. **Cold emails are about pointless,** unless you're already famous.
2. **The best way in** is a comic I already trust saying "book them."
3. **Chasing so-and-so's feature spot** is a 1:1 job, and it might suck. Build your own audience and work anywhere.
4. **Bring a draw before you ask for a weekend.** Sell 30 tickets somewhere and tell me about it.
5. **Answer the advance fast.** A clip, a short bio and a good photo make you easy to sell.
6. **Hang with fans. Sell smart merch. ENGAGE.** Get emails at the table. That list sells out shows.
7. **Hosts and features: promote too.** The $3 fee means a fuller room pays you more.
8. **It's called show business for a reason.** The show is half of it.

SELL THE ROOM.

WHEREVER YOU'RE PLAYING

- **Run ads from both sides.** The venue's ads find local comedy fans who don't know you yet. Yours reach the people who already do. You need both.
- **Ask the venue what they spend on ads,** and ask for the results after. Sales, not clicks.
- **Time your email blasts with their ads.** Tell them the dates.
- **Give them a 15-second clip.** Video beats a photo every time.
- **Post two weeks out, show week, and day of.** Use a tracked link so you know what your posts sold.

WHAT WE DO AT SISYPHUS, FOR EVERY HEADLINER AND FEATURE

- Run ads for your show, tracked by the pixel.
- **Match your ad spend dollar for dollar.** Up to $200 in the big room, up to $100 in the small room.
- Send you a real report after: tickets, ad spend, what sold.
- **100% of the door to you.** The $3 ticket fee goes 100% to host and feature pay.

We want you to do well. Every venue should.

WHAT HEADLINER #1'S WEEKEND PAID

$7,033
to the headliner, 100% of the door

$783
to host and feature, from the $3 fee

271
people in the room, 5 shows

HOW I MADE THE NUMBERS WORK

Opened in 2014 on $170k. Budget was $120k. Paid for with my 401k, a family loan, a home equity loan and every credit card that said yes.

Comedy was the plan from day one. Paid comics $10k in 2015. Paid them $157k in 2025.

Beer sales peaked in 2019, then plummeted immediately following a Sam Tallent headlining visit in March of 2020. I'm told there were other factors. The comedy kept growing.

The business kept $40k last year. I'm still here.

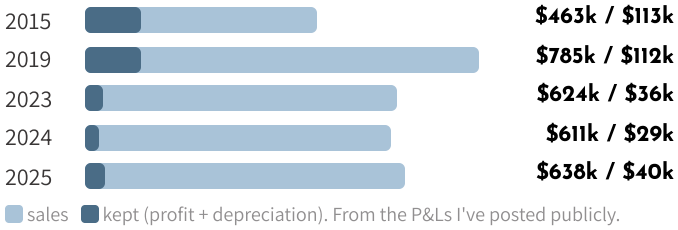
I've worked 60+ hour weeks for 13 years to make $1,000,000. Sounds great, until you do the per hour math = $24.65.

1 in 4
dollars we take in goes to comics. In 2015 it was 1 in 50.

> rent
Comics made $157k in 2025. The landlord got $121k.

4x
Comics took home 4x what the business kept.

SALES VS WHAT THE BUSINESS KEPT



WHY BOTHER

Pick a peak. "Hit that and I've made it." And you will feel like you made it, for a little bit. Then you're right back at it. In days, in weeks, in months.

So the question isn't how to get to the top. It's what makes you forget everything around you and focus on the here and now. What makes you want to greet the cold indifference of the universe head on, every day, through the triumph and the rejection.

For me, it's running what I try to make the best comedy club on the planet.

It's an impossible goal. But it's kind of fun to do the impossible.

-Sam

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